

SYED HUZAIFA BIN AFZAL

Tacoma, WA | +1 (206) 750-5956 | huzaifaafzal10@gmail.com | linkedin.com/in/syed-huzaifa-bin-afzal

ACADEMIC PROFILE

Graduate student in Cybersecurity & Leadership at the University of Washington with research interests in secure GenAI adoption, Shadow AI, AI governance, enterprise AI risk, data residency, RBAC, and human-centered AI deployment. Combines cloud infrastructure experience with academic research, technical writing, and public-facing reporting on AI in higher education. Suitable for AI research assistant, academic program, AI governance, cybersecurity research, applied AI lab, and research communication roles.

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Secure enterprise GenAI deployment and governance
- Shadow AI risk, acceptable-use controls, and institutional AI policy
- AI security, data residency, access control, and role-based platform administration
- Evaluation of AI tools for drafting, summarization, code assistance, and knowledge-work workflows
- Human-centered AI adoption in universities and organizations
- Cloud infrastructure foundations for safe and reliable AI systems

EDUCATION

- University of Washington - Master of Cybersecurity & Leadership — Expected June 2026 | GPA: 3.99 | Beta Gamma Sigma | Upsilon Pi Epsilon
- Ghulam Ishaq Khan Institute of Engineering Sciences and Technology - B.S. Computer Science, 2019

PUBLICATIONS AND RESEARCH OUTPUT

- Co-author, "Are You Aware of Shadow AI? GovernAI for Addressing Emerging Risks" - accepted for IEEE Silicon Valley Cybersecurity Conference (SVCC) 2026.
- Author, "Building the future with AI: Purple UW students join forces with UW-IT to shape next-gen AI" - The Tacoma Ledger, Oct. 13, 2025.

RESEARCH PROJECTS

GovernAI - Shadow AI and Secure Enterprise GenAI Platform | University of Washington | Jun 2025 - Present

- Built an on-prem GenAI platform to study how organizations can provide internal AI capabilities while reducing unmanaged Shadow AI use.
- Implemented a practical platform design using Ollama, Open WebUI, Docker, Windows Server, RBAC concepts, host firewall controls, and network behavior checks.
- Evaluated platform behavior against enterprise AI concerns including data residency, user access boundaries, model control, acceptable use, and administrative oversight.
- Compared internal AI workflows against ChatGPT, Microsoft 365 Copilot, and Gemini Pro for drafting, summarization, and code-related tasks.
- Mapped findings and control ideas to NIST AI RMF and ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Annex A concepts for academic discussion of governance and risk reduction.
- Co-authored accepted IEEE SVCC 2026 paper on Shadow AI and GovernAI.

AI in Higher Education Reporting and Field Interviews | University of Washington Tacoma | Sep 2025 - Present

- Reported on UW AI initiatives, including UW Purple and AI-in-education programs, with emphasis on adoption, training, institutional readiness, and student impact.
- Conducted interviews with administrators, faculty, students, and technology leaders to capture how AI systems are explained, governed, and adopted in practice.
- Produced clear public-facing writing that connects technical AI topics with governance, education, and institutional decision-making.

RESEARCH AND TECHNICAL METHODS

- Qualitative Methods: stakeholder interviews, technical reporting, requirements gathering, comparative tool evaluation, documentation synthesis
- Security and Governance Frameworks: NIST AI RMF concepts, ISO/IEC 27001:2022 Annex A concepts, access control, risk mapping, privacy-aware deployment review
- AI Tool Evaluation: prompt testing, workflow comparison, hallucination/failure-mode awareness, drafting and summarization evaluation, code-assistance review
- Systems and Infrastructure: AWS, Terraform, Docker, Windows Server, Linux, IAM, RBAC, CloudWatch, Datadog, OpenSearch, Redis, S3, Redshift, EMR, Jenkins
- Programming and Analysis: Python, Bash, PowerShell, Java, MATLAB, Git, Wireshark, documentation, reproducible technical notes

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE RELEVANT TO RESEARCH

DevOps Engineer | Harri via Kalam 4 Solutions | Mar 2022 - May 2025

- Operated production AWS infrastructure and implemented Terraform automation, providing practical grounding in the systems, security, and reliability issues that shape AI deployment.

- Worked on IAM, SSO, RBAC, Systems Manager, monitoring, cost optimization, and disaster-recovery readiness, all relevant to secure AI platform governance.
- Developed analytics and infrastructure visibility workflows using S3 Inventory, Redshift, and Superset, strengthening applied data and platform research context.

Cloud Infrastructure / Software Engineer | Visionet Systems via Systems Limited | Jul 2019 - Mar 2022

- Supported AWS automation, EMR migration, ECS workloads, observability, and CI/CD pipelines across client environments.
- Built scripts and runbooks for operational repeatability and system validation, useful for research prototypes and controlled platform evaluation.

Student News Reporter | University of Washington Tacoma | Sep 2025 - Present

- Write university news and AI/IT coverage, conduct interviews, and explain technical developments to general audiences.
- Experience supports research dissemination, literature-to-practice translation, and communication with faculty, students, and institutional leaders.

CONFERENCE / ACADEMIC FIT NOTES

- Strong fit for research assistant roles involving AI governance, AI security, enterprise AI adoption, cybersecurity policy, applied AI systems, or educational technology.
- Can support literature review, prototype deployment, qualitative interviews, technical documentation, experiment notes, and research communication.
- Best-positioned research narrative: secure GenAI adoption in real organizations, especially the gap between user demand for AI tools and institutional controls needed to reduce Shadow AI risk.

CERTIFICATIONS

- AWS Certified Solutions Architect - Associate
- Oracle Cloud Infrastructure Architect - Professional
- Oracle Cloud Infrastructure Developer - Associate
- Foundations for Cybersecurity Analytics - University of Washington

HONORS

- Top Performer Award, Harri - 2023 and 2024
- Best Team Award, Systems Limited - 2020
- 1st Position Final Year Project, LifeTrack - GIKI